

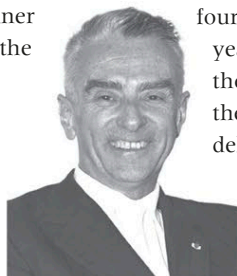
A European Space Agency
Airbus A300 in 2004



Great Manufacturers Airbus

Established in 1970 to compete with Boeing in the US, Airbus has produced more than a dozen civil and military designs. These range from small, short-haul airliners to the largest airliner in the world, while its military division produces strategic tanker and transport aircraft and its flagship tactical airlifter.

THE AIRBUS STORY BEGAN in the 1960s when French, British, and German ministers agreed to work together to produce an airliner to compete with Boeing in the growing package vacation market. In 1967, they signed a Memorandum of Understanding, of which one key point was that the French company Sud Aviation would be the "lead company."



Roger Béteille
(1921-)

Three years later, Airbus Industrie was formed to develop the new, twin-engined, wide-bodied aircraft. The British government withdrew its support, leaving Airbus to find an engine manufacturer—General Electric was selected. Hawker Siddeley, well regarded for its wing design expertise, continued as a major subcontractor. Airbus Industrie was equally split between France and West Germany until Spain became part of it in 1971. At its Toulouse factory, the first Airbus A300B1 was assembled and, on October 28, 1972, it made its maiden flight. In May 1974, the

Airbus A300B2 (the first production model) entered service with Air France. Orders were slow at first, with four A300s supplied in the first year, rising to a total of 58 by the end of 1978. However, in the late 1970s and early 1980s, delivery levels increased,

peaking in 1982 when 46 aircraft were supplied.

Equipping passenger and cargo airlines around the world, 561 Airbus

A300s had been built by

the time production ceased in March 2007. Five of the late variant A300-600s underwent modifications to enable them to transport major Airbus airframe components. These A300-600ST Belugas have a cargo capacity similar to the largest military transporters.

The smaller, rewinged and reengined Airbus A310 was launched in 1978 to meet a request from airlines that could not justify flying the A300 on shorter routes. Early on in the Airbus A310 program, Britain joined Airbus Industrie and became heavily involved in development of this type. Extensively modified from the A300, most obviously in its shorter fuselage, the A310 flew for the first time in April 1982. The airlines' support was strong and, as its wheels lifted off the runway at Toulouse, no less than 15 customers had already ordered examples for their fleets. Adding to its widespread commercial service, the Airbus A310 was also acquired by a number of international air forces as a transport. In 2003, more than two decades after



Airbus factory in China

Wings made in the Chinese factory in Tianjin are applied to an Airbus A320 in 2010. This is the company's first final assembly line outside Europe, and it opened in 2008.

the Airbus A310's introduction, a dedicated air refueling variant was flown. This Airbus A310 MRTT version is used by the German Air Force and the Royal Canadian Air Force.

With the Airbus A310 selling well, Airbus Industrie turned to its first narrow-bodied twin-jet airliner. For the first time, a digital fly-by-wire control system was employed—a feature previously found only in military aircraft. The A320 made its first flight in February 1987, and more than 400 planes were ordered. Still in production, the 150/180-seat A320 has spawned a series of variants: the stretched A321 (which provides greater capacity), the 124/156-seat A319, and the shorter A318 with 107/117 seats.

The next Airbus airliners to appear were the four-engined A340 and the twin-jet A330. Both were larger than

the A300 and were intended to fly on long-range routes. As with the Airbus A310, the A330 was also converted into a military variant—the A330 MRTT—to act as a combined transport aircraft and an air-to-air refueler. The A330 MRTT has been ordered by four air forces to date, including the Royal Air Force, with whom it is in service as the Voyager KC2.



Collaborative effort

This German stamp produced in 1988 shows the Airbus A320 in flight. The plane was built as a result of a successful collaboration between France, West Germany, and the UK.

